



Levels of consciousness

In the early 20th century, neurologist Sigmund Freud popularized the idea that the mind is divided into three levels of consciousness: the conscious mind (mental processes we are aware of), the preconscious (processes we are not aware of but can be brought into the conscious), and the unconscious (inaccessible mental processes that influence our behavior). More modern thinking suggests that there are several levels of consciousness, ranging from intense self-reflection to the deepest sleep.



Introspection

We examine our thoughts, actions, and emotions—for example, we may brood over an action we have taken.



Normal consciousness

We have a sense of agency—we believe that we control our thoughts and that they influence what we do.



Unconscious knowledge

We can perform complex tasks, though may not have a memory of doing so—for example, not remembering the drive home.



Lack of consciousness

Asleep, we neither perceive the world around us nor have the sense of self to experience things such as time passing.

**95 PERCENT
OF OUR DECISIONS
ARE MADE BY OUR
UNCONSCIOUS MIND**



Ironical process theory

If we are asked not to think of a white bear, we will probably think of a white bear. This is because a deliberate attempt to suppress a thought makes it more likely to occur. This phenomenon is explained by an idea known as ironic process theory. The idea is that the brain unconsciously monitors itself for occurrences of the unwanted thought—which, ironically, then makes us aware of the thought. This is partly why quitting smoking is difficult or why trying to forget a bad memory rarely works—the unconscious reminds us of the things we are trying to forget.



MAKING DECISIONS

In 2006, two Dutch researchers asked subjects to make a complex decision under one of three conditions: with little time for consideration; with ample time; or with ample time but distractions that prevented conscious thought about the decision. In all cases, the distracted subjects performed best. The findings suggest that people can make better decisions unconsciously than consciously—although the experiment suggested this is true only when we are making complicated decisions.

